fig. 00 — manual

# mercy.

## A drum processor inspired by three eras of Kanye West: My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy, Watch the Throne and Yeezus.

version 2 · windows (vst3 · clap) · mac, apple silicon (au · vst3 · clap)

by slapworx

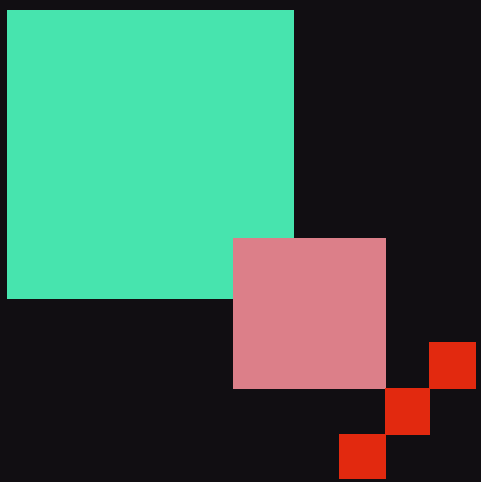


fig. 01 — contents

# inside.


01 install 03
the installers for windows and mac, and finding MERCY in your DAW

02 quick start 04
a good sound in a minute

03 the three eras 05
fantasy, throne, yeezus

04 the main page 06
squash, dirt, age, meters, filters, the bottom bar

05 the advanced page 08
ten modules, the chain order, module presets

06 presets 11
seven groups, saving, renaming, deleting

07 bake 12
print MERCY's sound into audio files: single, bulk

08 capture 14
record or grab what you hear, snapped to the bar

09 controls and tips 15
mouse, keyboard, sizing, the look

10 troubleshooting 16
and where your files live

01

# install.

## windows 64-bit · VST3 + CLAP

01 Close your DAW.

02 Unzip the download and double-click **Install MERCY.exe**.

03 If Windows shows **"Windows protected your PC"**, click **More info**, then **Run anyway**. Then click **Yes** when Windows asks to allow changes.

04 Click **Next**, keep **VST3** and **CLAP** ticked (or untick the one you don't use), then **Install**.

05 Open your DAW and scan for new plugins. FL Studio: **Options › Manage plugins › Find installed plugins**. MERCY is listed under **slapworx**.

To remove MERCY: **Settings › Apps › Installed apps › MERCY (slapworx) › Uninstall**. Your presets and bakes are kept.

## mac apple silicon (m1 and newer) · AU + VST3 + CLAP

01 Quit your DAW.

02 Unzip the download and double-click **Install MERCY.pkg**.

03 If macOS says it can't check the installer, **right-click** (or Control-click) it, choose **Open**, then **Open** again.

04 Click **Continue**. On the next screen, keep **Audio Unit**, **VST3** and **CLAP** ticked, or untick what you don't use. Click **Install** and enter your Mac password.

05 Open your DAW. In Logic Pro and GarageBand, MERCY is under **Audio Units › slapworx › Mercy**.

> **Installing by hand** instead? The plain plugin files are in the **manual install** folder. Windows: copy `Mercy.vst3` into `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\` and `Mercy.clap` into `C:\Program Files\Common Files\CLAP\` (unblock the zip first: right-click › Properties › Unblock). Mac: copy them into `/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/` (Components, VST3, CLAP). If macOS then won't open them, run this in Terminal:
>
> ```
> sudo xattr -dr com.apple.quarantine /Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/Mercy.component
> /Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/Mercy.vst3 /Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/CLAP/Mercy.clap
> ```

Intel Macs aren't supported. MERCY sounds exactly the same on Windows and Mac: every build is checked so both render bit-identical audio, and presets and projects move between them freely.

02

# quick start.

MERCY goes on drums: a break, a loop, a kit bus, a kick or a snare. Put it on the track as an insert effect.

01 **Pick an era** at the top: **fantasy**, **throne** or **yeezus**. Each one is a whole voicing of the chain.

02 **Or pick a preset.** Click the preset name in the bottom bar (it opens on "default break") and choose from 76 presets in seven groups, or step through them with the ‹ › arrows.

03 **Shape it with the three big sliders: squash** (compression), **dirt** (saturation and clipping) and **age** (sampler crunch). The middle of each slider is the preset's own setting.

04 **Blend it** with **mix**, and keep **auto gain** on so louder never fools you into thinking better. Use **output** to sit it in the mix.

05 **Go deeper** on the **advanced** page: ten modules you can tweak, switch off and reorder.

06 **Print it.** Open **bake** on the advanced page and drop audio on it, or capture what's playing, and drag the result straight into your DAW.

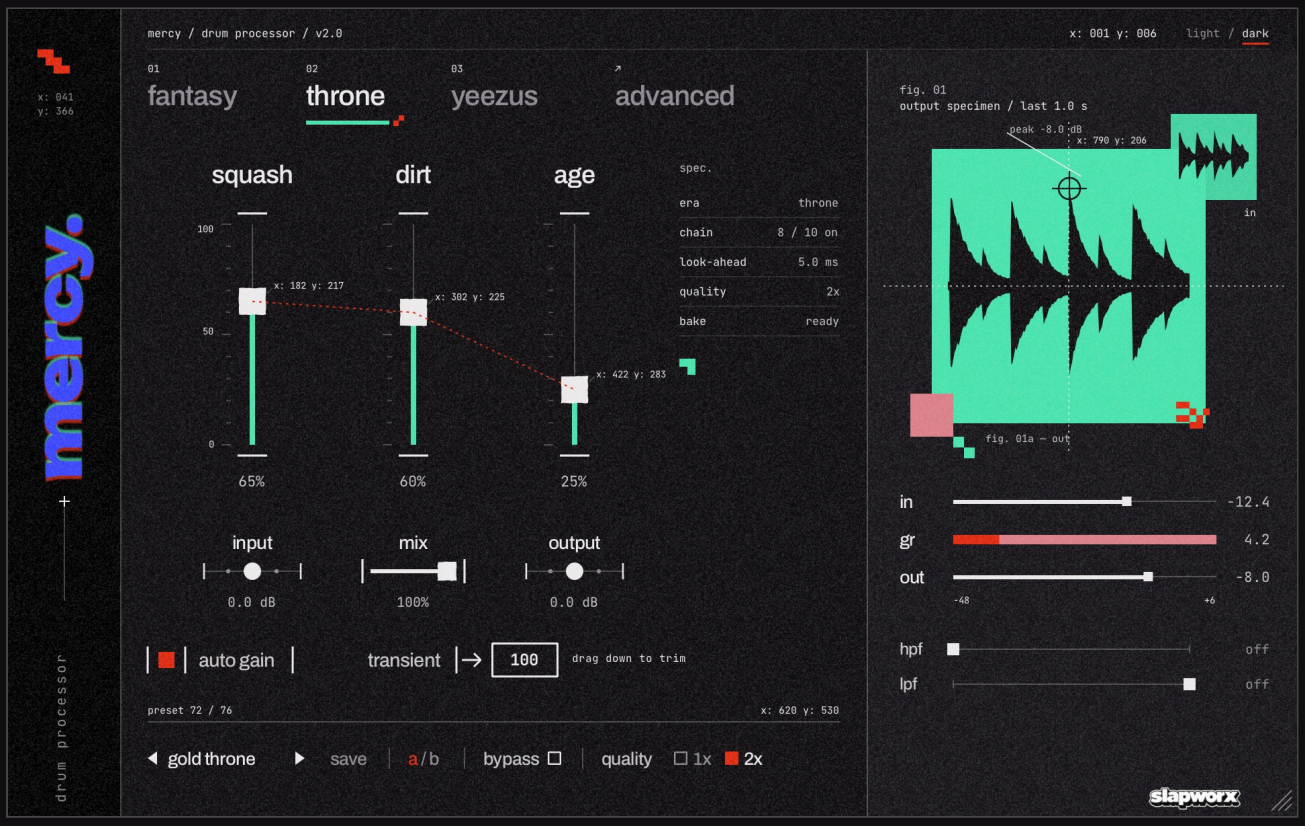



fig. 1 — the main page, dark look, preset "gold throne".

03

# three eras.

The era tabs are MERCY's biggest control. Each one changes the voicing of the whole chain and sets the advanced page up for that sound. The interface takes the era's colors too.

## fantasy

2010

Inspired by **My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy**: big, glossy and dark. Huge snares, thick lows, a polished mix that still hits hard.

Sets up: a **plate** verb, a little **weight** and some preamp **thick**.

## throne

2011

Inspired by **Watch the Throne**: soul-sample swagger, punchy and expensive. Tight rooms, crisp chops, gold-plated compression.

Sets up: a **room** verb and a little **thick**.

## yeezus

2013

Inspired by **Yeezus**: industrial, distorted and confrontational. Crushed low end, hard clipping, gates that slam shut.

Sets up: a **gated** verb and heavy **weight**, with no thick, because the crushed low end is the point.

## what clicking an era does

- Changes the voicing of every stage and loads that era's starting point into the advanced page.
- Leaves **transient** and **shape** alone, so your trim and transient shaping stay as they are.
- Sets the **verb** up for the era (plate, room or gated) but **doesn't switch it on**. Turn it on yourself on the advanced page when you want space.
- Presets can use any era. The tab shows which one a preset is built on.

04

# main page.

## the three sliders

| control | what it does |
|---|---|
| squash | Compression with a parallel blend. Higher = more glue and pump, lower = more open. |
| dirt | Preamp saturation feeding the clipper. Higher = more grit, edge and loudness. |
| age | The sampler stage: lower sample rate, fewer bits and pitch crunch, like an old drum sampler. All the way down = off. |

At the middle (12 o'clock), squash and dirt use exactly what's set on the advanced page. Turn them up or down to push or pull those settings without opening it.

## level and blend

| | |
|---|---|
| input | Level into MERCY (−24 to +24 dB). More input drives every stage harder. |
| mix | Dry / processed blend. 100% = fully processed. |
| output | Final level (−24 to +24 dB). |
| auto gain | Keeps the output about as loud as the input, so you judge the sound and not the volume. On by default. |
| transient \|→ 100 | An Ableton-style transient trim ("Beats" warp with preserve transients). Drag the box down to chop the tail of every hit shorter. 100 = off; the box turns red when it's working. |

## fig. 01 and the meters

| | |
|---|---|
| fig. 01 | The live output over the last second, drawn like a printed waveform. The crosshair sits on the loudest hit with its peak level. The small square in the corner is the input, so you see before and after at a glance. |
| in / gr / out | Input level, gain reduction (the red part) and output level. |
| hpf / lpf | Gentle high-pass (20 Hz–2 kHz) and low-pass (20 kHz–500 Hz) filters after everything else. Far left / far right = off. |
| spec. | A small readout: era, how many modules are on, look-ahead, quality and bake status. |

## the bottom bar

| | |
|---|---|
| ‹ preset › | The current preset. Click the name for the full preset list (page 11); the arrows step to the previous or next preset. A * after the name means you've changed it since loading. |
| save | Name and save your own preset. |
| a / b | Two slots to compare settings. Click to switch between a and b; each remembers its own sound. |
| bypass | Hear the dry signal. |
| quality 1x / 2x | 2x runs MERCY oversampled: cleaner distortion and clipping, a little more CPU. Bakes always use 2x. |

## the top bar

| | |
|---|---|
| fantasy / throne / yeezus | The era (page 05). |
| advanced | Opens the advanced page. Click it again to come back. |
| light / dark | Switches the look. Your choice is saved with the project. |

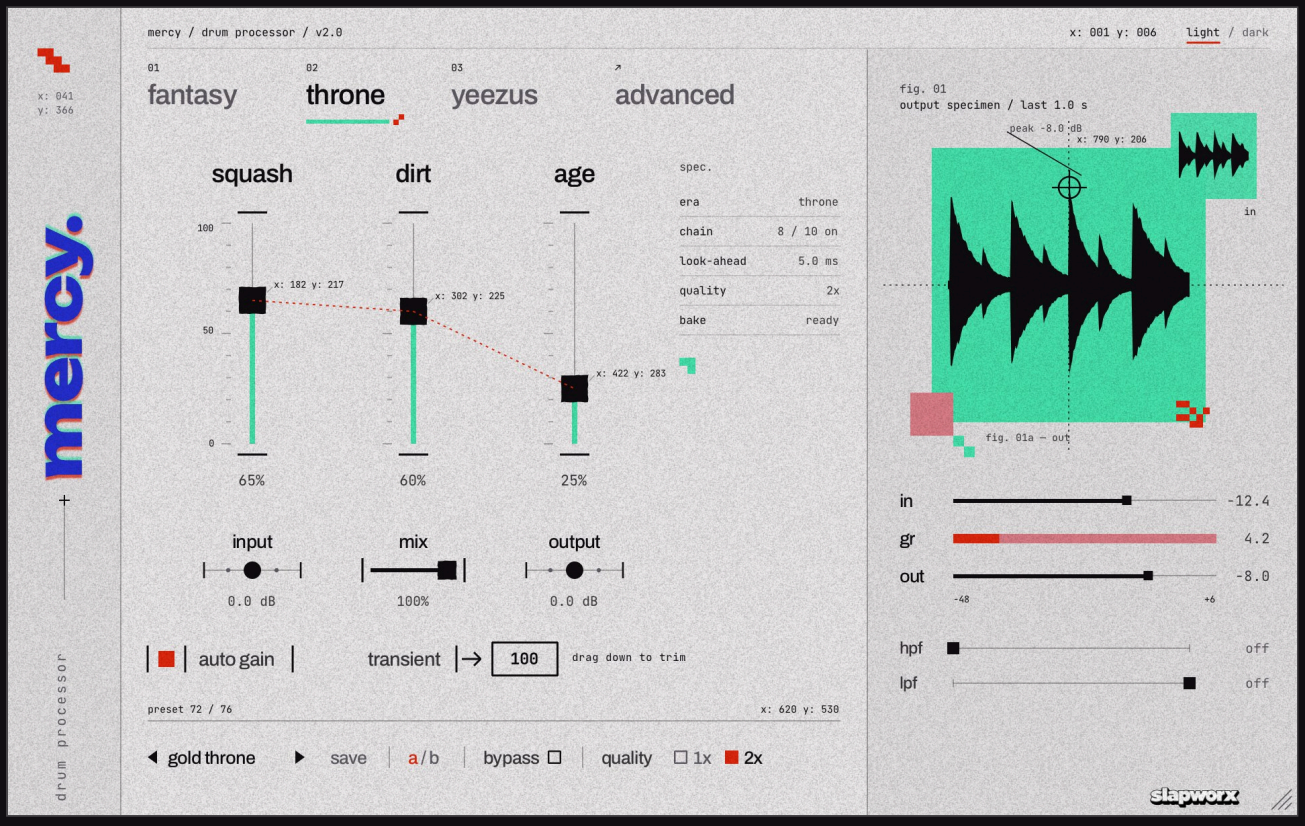



fig. 2 — the same page in the light look.

MERCY adds a 5 ms look-ahead (so the transient tools catch the very front of each hit). It reports this to your DAW, which lines everything up for you.

05

# advanced.

Ten modules, in the order the sound flows through them: left to right, top row then bottom row.

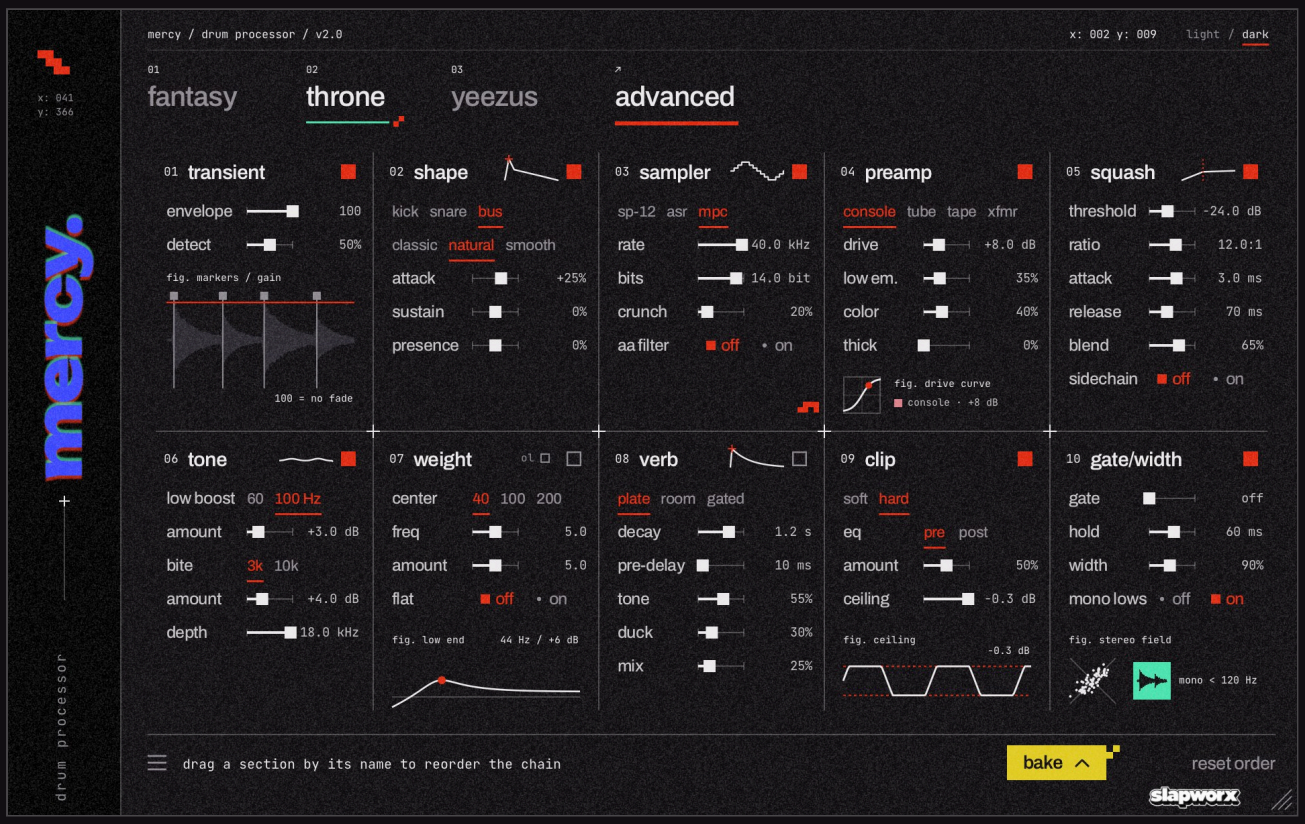



fig. 3 — the advanced page.

- **On / off:** the red square at the top right of each module switches it on or off.
- **Reorder the chain:** drag a module by its name onto another slot. The others slide over to make room while you drag. **reset order** (bottom right) puts the chain back. Presets can set their own order.
- **Module presets:** click a module's name (without dragging) for a small list of presets for just that module. Picking one changes only that module; **default** puts it back to its starting point for the current era.
- **Figures:** the small drawings in each module react to your settings: transient markers, the drive curve, the clip ceiling, the stereo field and more.

# the modules

## tr transient

The Ableton-style trim from the main page. It only takes away: each hit restarts a fade, so tails get shorter.

**envelope** 0–100 (100 = no fade) · **detect** how easily hits are picked up

## sm sampler

Old drum-sampler character: the grit and pitch crunch of classic 12-bit machines.

**sp-12 / asr / mpc** model · **rate** 4–44.1 kHz · **bits** 4–16 · **crunch** · **aa filter** smooths the aliasing

## sq squash

Compressor with a parallel blend.

**threshold** · **ratio** 1–20:1 · **attack** 0.1–30 ms · **release** 20–500 ms · **blend** dry/compressed · **sidechain** high-pass, so the kick doesn't pump everything

## wt weight

A bass resonance tool, measured against and matched to UAD's Little Labs Voice of God: same controls, same numbers. It starts off; the fantasy and yeezus eras switch it on.

**center 40 / 100 / 200** 61–20 Hz (subs, 808s), 171–57 Hz (kick body), 306–102 Hz · **freq** 0 = top of the range, 10 = bottom · **amount** 0 = flat, 10 = full resonance (up to about +18 dB) with a steep cut under it · **flat** the same bump with the lows under it left alone. The **ol** light flashes red when weight pushes past 0 dB.

## cl clip

The final edge.

**soft / hard** · **eq pre / post** swaps the order of tone and clip · **amount** · **ceiling** –12 to 0 dB

## sh shape

A transient shaper that can add or remove attack and sustain.

**kick / snare / bus** what you're feeding it · **classic / natural / smooth** character · **attack** and **sustain** –100 to +100% · **focus** aims it at one range (tight on kick, body on snare, presence on bus). All at 0 = no change.

## pr preamp

Saturation in four flavors.

**console / tube / tape / xfmr** flavor · **drive** 0–24 dB · **low em.** low-end emphasis · **color** · **thick** lets the lows go around the saturation (the split rises from 60 to 250 Hz as you turn it up), so the top gets the grit and the kick and sub stay full. 0 = off.

## to tone

Broad, musical EQ moves.

**low boost 60 / 100 Hz** + amount (0–12 dB) · **bite 3k / 10k** + amount · **depth** a top-end roll-off, 2–20 kHz

## rv verb

A reverb tuned for drums. The kick stays out of it (built-in low cut). Off unless you turn it on.

**plate / room / gated** mode · **decay** 0.1–4 s (called **length** in gated mode: how long the tail stays open) · **pre-delay** 0–100 ms · **tone** dark to bright · **duck** pushes the tail down under each hit · **mix**

## gw gate/width

Gate and stereo image.

**gate** threshold (off at the bottom) · **hold** 5–500 ms · **width** 0–200% · **mono lows** keeps everything under 120 Hz in mono

# module presets

Click a module's name to open its own preset list. The preset that matches the module's current settings is marked in red.

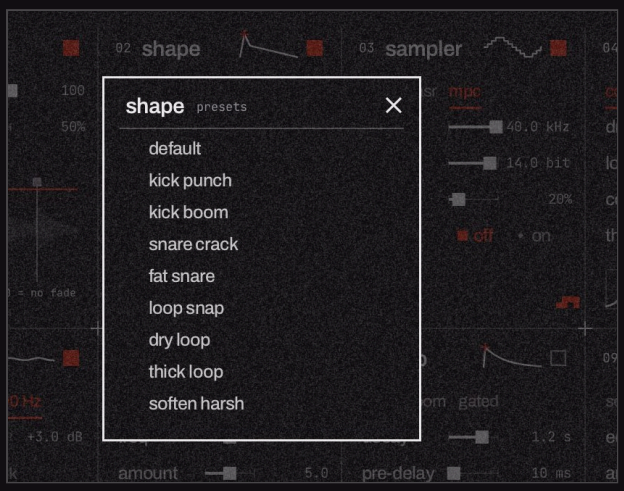



fig. 4 — shape's module presets.

| | |
|---|---|
| transient | light trim, tight, chopped, gated, catch ghosts, big hits only |
| shape | kick punch, kick boom, snare crack, fat snare, loop snap, dry loop, thick loop, soften harsh |
| sampler | sp-12 style, sp-12 pitched down, asr warm, asr grit, mpc60 style, mpc 2000 clean, crushed, am radio |
| preamp | console glue, console push, tube warmth, tube burn, tape, tape hot, iron, iron fuzz |
| squash | bus glue, punch, all buttons, parallel smash, pump, room lift, gentle |
| tone | warm, big low end, 100 hz thump, snare bite, air, dark, radio |
| weight | kick weight, 808 chest, sub bloom, kick body, tight thump, snare body, big weight |
| verb | snare plate, big plate, dark plate, tight room, drum room, big room, gated snare, industrial gate, long gate |
| clip | clean, soft kiss, soft loud, hard edge, hard slam, low ceiling grit |
| gate/width | wide, open stereo, narrow, mono, tight gate, choke |

Every list also has **default**, which puts the module back to its starting point (for modules the era drives, the current era's setting).

## why the order matters

Moving a module changes what it works on. A few ideas that presets in the list use:

- **Verb early:** the transient trim chops the reverb tail, squash pumps it, or the gate cuts it short.
- **Clip before squash:** the compressor tames the clipped peaks for a denser, flatter hit.
- **Sampler last:** everything gets crunched together, like resampling a finished loop.
- **Weight last:** the low-end bump goes on after the saturation instead of being flattened by it.

06

# presets.

Click the preset name in the bottom bar to open the list. 76 factory presets, grouped by what they do to the sound. The bar under the title jumps straight to a group, and the red underline follows the group you're looking at as you scroll.

| | |
|---|---|
| `start` 6 | clean starting points: nothing, default break, glue |
| `punch` 13 | compression and transients: snap, parallel smash, tape glue |
| `grit` 15 | sampler, lo-fi, crunch: sp-12 crunch, mpc thump, dusty vinyl |
| `low end` 9 | weight and sub: 808 weight, sub bloom, kick body |
| `space` 19 | the reverb presets: plate snare, dark plate, drowned break |
| `gated` 6 | gated snare, gated toms, industrial gate |
| `eras` 8 | the signature sounds: dark fantasy, gold throne, yeezus raw |

**nothing** switches every module off: no processing at all. Start from it to build a sound from scratch.

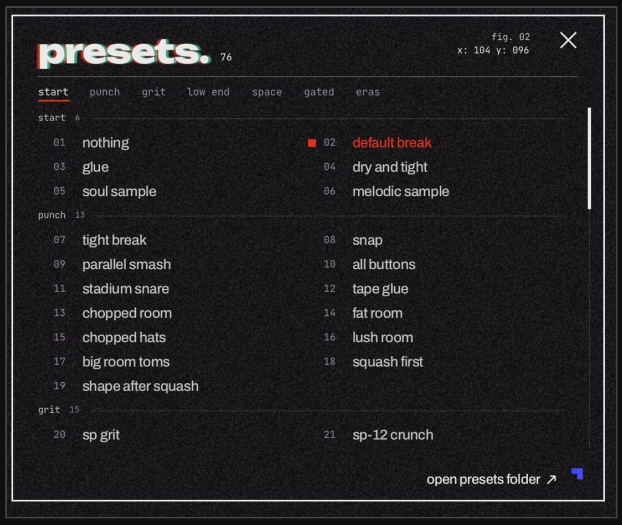



fig. 5 — the preset list.

## your own presets

- **save** (bottom bar) opens a name box. Type a name and press `Enter`. The suggested name is selected, so you can just start typing. `Esc` cancels.
- Your presets appear in a **user** group at the end of the list (and in the group bar once you have one).
- **Rename or delete:** right-click one of your presets, or hover it and click the small **×**. Delete always asks "delete? yes / no" first. Factory presets can't be changed.
- Deleting the preset you're using doesn't change your sound; the name just goes back to "default break *".
- **open presets folder** (bottom of the list) opens the folder with your presets file. It's one text file, the same on Windows and Mac, so you can copy it between computers.

07

# bake.

Print MERCY's sound into audio files without leaving the plugin. Open it with **bake** at the bottom right of the advanced page.

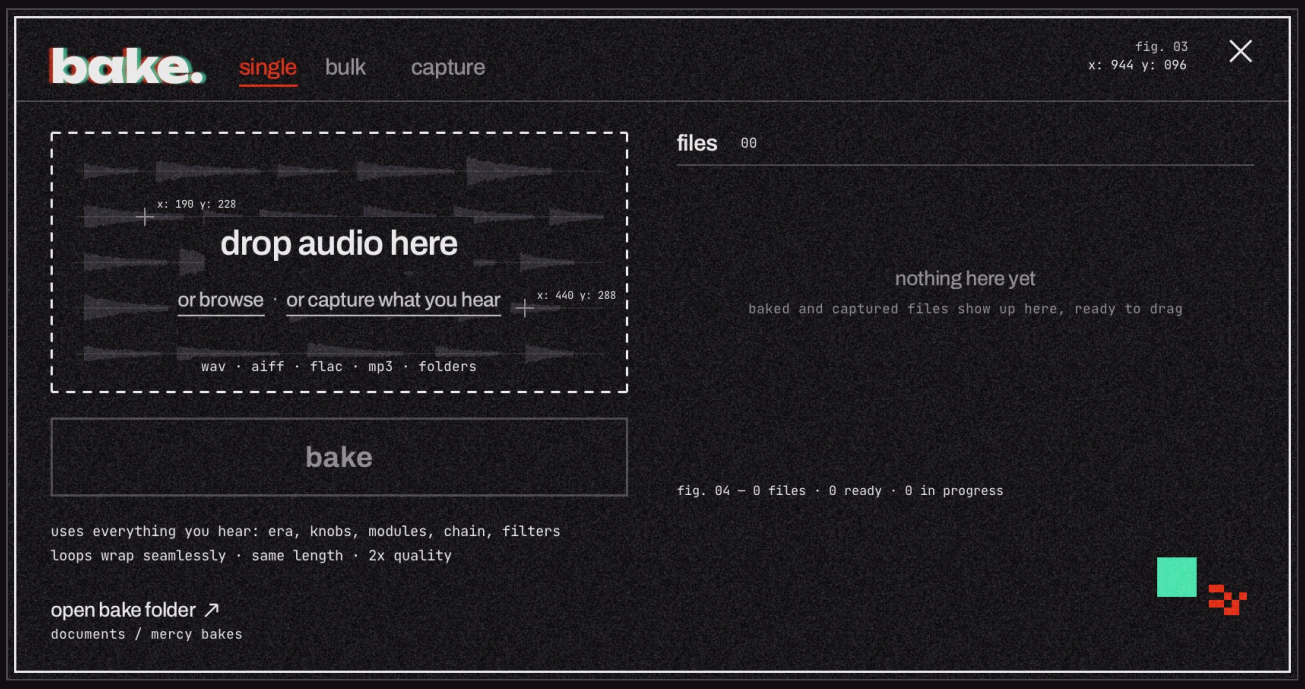



fig. 6 — the bake panel.

## single

01 Dial in a sound you like.

02 Drag audio onto the drop zone: from your DAW's browser, Explorer or Finder. Loops, one-shots, stems or full beats; wav, aiff, flac or mp3. Or click **or browse**.

03 Press **bake**.

04 Grab the finished file by its **drag →** handle and drop it into your DAW: the playlist, a track, a sampler. Then drop the next file.

Change your settings and press bake again to re-bake with the new sound.

## bulk

- Drop many files at once, or a whole folder (subfolders too). MERCY switches to bulk by itself.
- Press **bake all**. Then drag the files out one by one, all together with **drag all →**, or press **export to desktop** to put the whole batch in a new folder on your desktop (for example "Mercy – gold throne – Oct 30"), which opens when it's done.

## what a bake does

- Uses **everything you hear**: era, sliders, every module, the chain order, transient, filters, mix, output and auto gain.
- Always renders at **2x quality**, and ignores bypass.
- Keeps the **exact length and timing** of the original. Loops wrap seamlessly: MERCY warms up on the loop first, so the first hit sounds like every other hit and the end flows into the start.
- Writes **24-bit WAV** at the file's own sample rate. If the result would go over 0 dB, it's saved as 32-bit float instead so nothing clips ("32-bit" in the list). Turn output down if you'd rather have 24-bit.
- Names files after the original and the preset, like `amen_mercy_gold-throne.wav`, in **Documents › Mercy Bakes**. Nothing is ever overwritten. **open bake folder** opens it.
- Runs in the background, so your DAW keeps playing smoothly. Bakes carry on while the plugin window is closed.

## good to know

- MP3s carry a little encoder silence at the edges, so MP3 bakes come out slightly longer and won't loop perfectly. Use WAV for loops.
- With the sampler on, every pass of a loop varies very slightly (live too), so a bake can't be bit-identical to one live pass. With the sampler off, a bake is bit-identical to what MERCY plays live.
- If dragging files in or out ever doesn't work in your DAW, use **or browse** to load and **open bake folder** to grab the results.

08

# capture.

Bake what you hear, live. The **capture** tab in the bake panel records MERCY's output while your track plays, snapped to your DAW's bars, so loops come out whole and line up to the sample.

## grab last N bars

Just played something great? Press **grab** and MERCY saves the last N bars that fully played. It's always listening: the strip at the top shows the recent history.

## record

Press **record** to arm. Recording starts on the next bar line and stops by itself after N bars. With **free**, it runs until you press **stop**, which finishes the current bar so the loop stays whole.

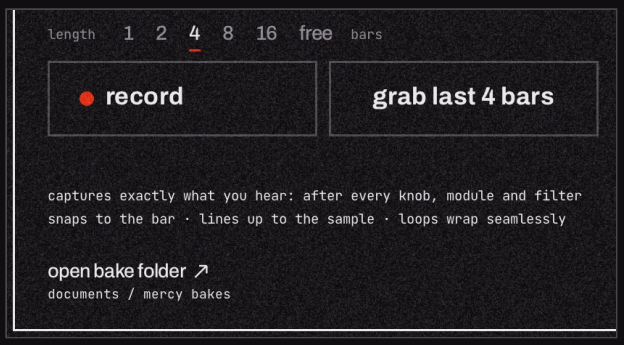



fig. 7 — the capture controls.

## length

**1**, **2**, **4**, **8**, **16** bars, or **free**.

- Captures exactly what you hear: after every slider, module and filter.
- With the transport stopped, record starts on the first sound and the silence after you stop is trimmed.
- MERCY starts listening the first time you open the bake panel in a session, and keeps about a minute of history.
- Takes are saved next to your bakes as `capture_<preset>_<bpm>bpm_<n>bars_001.wav`, show up in the same file list and drag out the same way.

09

# controls.

| do this | to |
|---|---|
| drag | adjust a control |
| shift + drag | adjust finely |
| double-click | reset a control to its default |
| mouse wheel | nudge a control, or scroll a list |
| right-click | type an exact value; `Enter` confirms, `Esc` cancels |
| bottom-right corner | drag to resize the window, 75% to 200% |
| Esc | close an open list or panel |

## tips

- **Judge at equal loudness.** Keep auto gain on, or level-match with output before you compare with bypass.
- **Use a / b** to compare two directions without losing either.
- **Quality 2x** is cleaner on heavy dirt and clipping. Switch to 1x on a big session if you need the CPU.
- **Starting points for shape:** tighter kick: kick, natural, attack +40, sustain −20, tight +40 · snappy snare: snare, natural, attack +50 · dry roomy loop: bus, natural, sustain −50 · thick loop: bus, smooth, sustain +40.
- Some presets can peak a little above 0 dB on breaks that already sit near 0 dBFS. Pull output down if your master clips.
- MERCY remembers where you were: page, panels, preset, a/b slots and the look are saved with your project.
- Motion follows your system: if "reduce motion" (Mac) or animations (Windows) are off, MERCY's animations are too.

10

# help.

| if | try |
|---|---|
| **MERCY doesn't show up** | Run the installer again (close your DAW first), then rescan. FL Studio: Options › Manage plugins › Find installed plugins. Logic: Settings › Plug-in Manager, select MERCY › Reset & Rescan Selection. |
| **Windows blocks the installer** | On "Windows protected your PC", click More info › Run anyway. |
| **macOS blocks the installer** | Right-click Install MERCY.pkg › Open › Open. |
| **"couldn't be replaced"** | The plugin is in use: close your DAW completely and run the installer again. |
| **Keys don't work in your DAW** | While a name box or typed value is open, MERCY takes the keyboard. Press Enter or Esc and your DAW's shortcuts come back. |
| **The master clips** | Pull output down, or lower dirt and clip amount. |
| **Drag and drop doesn't work** | Use "or browse" to load files and "open bake folder" to grab the results. |
| **Automation shows odd numbers** | DAW automation lanes show raw values (0.5 instead of 50%). That's normal. |

## where your files live

| | |
|---|---|
| **bakes and captures** | Windows `Documents\Mercy Bakes` · Mac `Documents/Mercy Bakes` |
| **your presets** | Windows `%APPDATA%\Mercy\user_presets.txt`<br>Mac `~/Library/Application Support/Mercy/user_presets.txt` |

## credits

MERCY is made by **slapworx**. Built with DPF (DISTRHO Plugin Framework, ISC license), the fonts Archivo, Unbounded and JetBrains Mono (SIL Open Font License) and dr_libs (public domain / MIT-0). The licenses are in the licenses folder.

MERCY is an independent product, not affiliated with or endorsed by Kanye West, Ableton or Universal Audio. Album titles and product names belong to their owners and are used only to describe the sounds that inspired MERCY.